CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

A NEW FOCUS: PHILANTHROPY

Ratan's Vision: 'Make a Difference'

Under Ratan, philanthropy has got a kind of makeover, with him employing his famous vision and gift for long-term strategic planning. It made philanthropy more meaningful and its outcomes more sustainable. Simultaneously, he has widened the scope of the Tatas' philanthropy to encompass more activities than were undertaken in the past.

His approach contrasts with that of the traditionalists, for whom philanthropy consisted of giving money, a less efficient way of assisting society. Money given as doles and donations seldom produces long-term results: it addresses the symptoms rather than the causes. Neither does it efficiently sustain change. Ratan has chiefly embraced the sustainable outcome model approach, which interestingly reflects the approach of the founder of the group.

Jamsetji did not prefer 'patchwork philanthropy which clothes the ragged, feeds the poor and heals the sick' as a model. He articulated his approach stating, 'I am far from decrying the noble spirit which seeks to help a poor or suffering fellow-being … [However] what advances a nation or a community is not so much to prop up its weakest and most helpless members, as to lift up the best and the most gifted, so as to make them of the greatest service to the country.'

Ratan's philosophy of philanthropy is also closer to that of the founder in terms of its desired outcomes. In an interview with Bridgespan Group, a non-profit consultancy, he said that his entire focus is to 'make a difference'. He added, 'If you cannot make a difference, if it's just water trickling through a tap or leading through a drainage system, it's wasteful.'